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Why detecting it is the wrong job

Most schools started with detection. It is worth knowing what that has cost, because it is the reason this page argues for design instead.

The detectors are not accurate enough to accuse a child with

A Stanford-led study published in 2023 tested seven AI-writing detectors. On essays by **non-native English writers** the average false positive rate was **61.3 percent**, and **97.8 percent** of the TOEFL essays were flagged by at least one detector. The mechanism is not mysterious: detectors key on how predictable the writing is, and a student still learning English writes in simpler, more predictable sentences.

So the tool is least reliable on exactly the students who can least afford to be wrongly accused.

Universities have been switching them off since 2023

Vanderbilt disabled Turnitin's AI detector in August 2023 and published why: with 75,000 papers a year, even a claimed one percent false positive rate is about **750 papers wrongly flagged**; the vendor would not explain how the score is produced; and the bias against non-native speakers was already there. Their conclusion was that AI detection software is not an effective tool and should not be used.

And the part nobody said

Even a detector that worked would only ever tell you something went wrong *after* a student spent an evening not learning anything. **A false accusation costs a relationship you cannot get back**, and a true one still leaves you with an assignment that taught nothing.

The alternative, and it is the same idea twice

In software there is a rule: **do not police the bad outcome, make it structurally unavailable**. A form that has no box for a last name cannot leak one. An assignment that only that student can answer cannot be answered by somebody else. Same move, two domains, and the second one needs no software at all.

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Each one, with a before and after

1 • Anchor it to something only that student has

Before: "Explain how supply and demand set prices." **After:** "Pick something you personally bought in the last month. Explain how supply and demand set what you paid for it."

A chatbot can write either answer. Only one of them needs a fact it does not have. **This is the cheapest of the four and usually the strongest.**

2 • Make everyone's version slightly different

Before: one worksheet, thirty copies. **After:** three or four variants — different numbers, a different text, a different starting condition — or let each student choose their own object, poem or data set.

Copying from the person beside you stops being useful, and a shared answer circulating in a group chat **only fits one person**. In my own units the computer builds a different version for every student from a **random seed**; **four variants on paper gets you most of the same effect**.

3 • Ask for the process, not the product

Before: "Submit your solution." **After:** "Submit your solution, plus the approach you tried first and why you abandoned it."

A finished answer is the easiest thing in the world to get from AI. **A dead end is not**, because the model never had one. This also happens to be the question that teaches the most, which is the test of whether a move is worth making.

4 • Make the second question depend on the first

Before: five independent questions. **After:** question two asks about the answer they gave to question one.

This is the one my own software leans on hardest, and page 4 is entirely about it.

Use one. Not four.

Rewriting every assignment this way is how this ends up in a drawer. Pick **the one assignment this month where copying actually costs you something**, apply move 1, and see what comes back.

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The follow-up question

One extra question, asked about the answer the student just gave. **A copied answer cannot survive it**, and a real one gets deeper. It costs you a line of typing.

Why it works when nothing else does

A student who wrote their own answer has reasons sitting right behind it. A student who pasted one has the words and nothing underneath. **You are not detecting anything** — you are asking a normal academic question that happens to require the thing a copy does not come with. Nobody gets accused, and nobody has to be.

A bank of stems. Pick one and paste it under any question.

Stem	What a copied answer does with it
"Why that and not the next most obvious answer?"	Produces a general defense that never names the alternative, because it does not know which one you meant.
"What would have to be different for your answer to be wrong?"	Goes vague. Conditions are flimsy and the answer never carries.
"Where did the number in your second sentence come from?"	Cannot point at it, because it was never derived.
"Say this to somebody who has not taken this class."	Re-states the same sentences in the same register instead of simplifying.

The thirty-second spoken version

Walk the room while they work and ask one student one stem out loud. It takes half a minute, it is not a confrontation, and it tells you more than any report ever will. **Do it with the students who are doing fine as well**, or it becomes a punishment and they will know.

One honest limit.

None of this stops a determined student, and it is not meant to. It **removes the easy win**, so copying costs more effort than the work would have. If a move only catches people and does not also make the task better, it is not on this page.

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WHAT IS INSIDE

Make the Copy Worthless

- ✓ **Why detecting it is the wrong job**, with the actual numbers
- ✓ Four moves, each with a before and an after
- ✓ **The follow-up question** a copied answer cannot survive
- ✓ A bank of stems to paste under any question
- ✓ **A fill-in page** so you leave with one assignment rewritten

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